Cara Ko

Visual artist and illustrator

Work exhibited at BRIC in Brooklyn, used in clinical presentations at the American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry Annual Meeting, and published in Clinical Case Reports.

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EDUCATION

Bergen County Academies,
Academy for Visual and Performing Arts, Hackensack, New Jersey
BCA teaches all academic courses at the honors level or above and does not rank.
ACT 35 · National Merit Commended Student, 2026 · National Honor Society, 2025 to 2027
Advanced coursework: IB History of the Americas I and II HL; IB Literature I and II HL; IB Mandarin ab initio; AP Studio Art; AP Art History; AP Calculus AB; AP Statistics; Visual Arts Capstone I and II
2023 to 2027

ADDITIONAL

HP LIFE certificates in Design Thinking and Social Media Marketing (July 2026)

BCA Orchestra, 2023 to 2025

Mandarin, three years

PROFESSIONAL ILLUSTRATION AND DESIGN

Studio Intern, Alfalfa Studio, New York — Fall 2026
Intern at the branding and graphic design studio led by Rafael Esquer, recipient of the Cooper Hewitt National Design Award. Taken for senior internship credit at BCA.

Medical Illustrator (commissioned), Kennedy Krieger Institute — 2024 to 2025
Illustrated patient behaviors that clinicians use to teach complex neuropsychiatric cases, including how to tell autism apart from reactive attachment disorder, PTSD, and selective mutism in preschoolers. Published and presented in:

- Dowling, Moxey, Keenan, and Hong, "A Preschooler With Severe Social Anxiety and Selective Mutism Versus Autism Spectrum Disorder," Clinical Case Reports 14 (2026): e73706; six figures, with acknowledgment
- Kennedy Krieger Complex Neuropsychiatric Case Conference, July and September 2024
- American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry Annual Meeting, Seattle, October 2024 (two sessions)
- American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry Annual Meeting, Chicago, October 2025 (extended workshop)

Designer and Design Lead, ***The Wait***, a YGLE initiative — 2025 to 2026
Designed, and led the team behind, a bilingual Korean and English patient communication kit for seniors: a six-panel fold-out card and a wallet card with body maps, pain scales, point-to phrases, and the legal right to an interpreter. Dentist-reviewed; 500 printed for distribution in New Jersey.

Illustrator, ***The Other Side***, seven-book children's series written by Ellie Kim (Walk Alongside Books) — 2026
About 40 illustrations across seven picture books on seeing another's point of view; four published on Amazon, three in production.

Illustrator, ***Red Boots Horsie***, children's book written by Gina Hong, published on Amazon — 2026

Head of Design Team, ***Personal Finance for Teens***, student-run financial literacy magazine, 50+ students in five teams
Sets each issue's theme and cover, assigns and draws illustrations, assembles the publication, and presents at outreach events.

Cover Artist, ***Bletter***, inaugural issue of a Korean bloggers' literary magazine — 2024

Blog Illustrator, ***Moonlake***, a Korean author's poetry blog — 2024

HONORS AND AWARDS

Art

Scholastic Art & Writing Awards
National Silver Medal (2024); two Gold Keys (2024); three Silver Keys (2026); five Honorable Mentions (2024, 2025, 2026)
2024 to 2026

American Art Awards
4th place, Expressionism; 5th place, Naive Art: Figure; 5th place, Religious and Spiritual; 6th place, Art Brut and/or Torment (all 2025). 6th place, Category 16 (2024)
2024 to 2025

Cooper Hewitt National High School Design Competition, Top Entry
2026

Korea Daily Student Art Contest, Happy Village Award
2025

Writing and Academics

John Locke Institute Global Essay Prize, High Commendation, History
2026

Scholastic Art & Writing Awards, Gold Key, Critical Essay
"The Harm of the Tampon Tax: A Symbol of Systematic Inequality Against Women"
2025

National Merit Scholarship Program, Commended Student
2026

Publication Awards (LitMag)

American Scholastic Press Association, First Place
2024

NCTE REALM Program, Excellent (2025); Honorable Mention (2026)
2025 to 2026

EXHIBITIONS AND CURATORIAL WORK

The Body Show, YM Studios Annual Senior Exhibition — Aug. 2026
Exhibited work, helped organize the exhibition, and designed its three posters.

Two Worlds Collide: Between Reality and Fantasy, Duo exhibition — Sept. to Oct. 2025
Exhibited work, helped organize the exhibition, and co-designed its poster.

Look At Me, BRIC Youth Curatorial Fellowship Exhibition, Brooklyn — May to Aug. 2025
Work selected for the exhibition; took part in the public discussion with the other selected artists.

Celebrating Her: Exploring the Diverse Experience of Women, Group exhibition — May to June 2024
Selected work; printed as postcards and sold to raise money for herFlow, a menstrual equity nonprofit.

BCA Holiday Card, Selected artwork; cards sold for the Visual Academy — 2025

COMMUNITY LEADERSHIP

Lead App Designer, VOY (Voices of the Young) — 2025 to present
Designs the screens and overall look of Mo Soop and Mo Ri, VOY's peer mental health apps.

Creative Director, Young Global Leaders of the East (YGLE) — 2024 to present
Owns YGLE's visual identity, including posters and the brand look. Young Leadership Award, Silver, 2025.

Director of Collections, Clothing Donations to Help Kids in the World (CDHW) — 2024 to present
Runs clothing collection drives for pediatric patients. Service Award for more than 100 hours, 2025.

Art Mentor and Tutor Team Leader, Walk Alongside — 2024 to present
Leads the art tutoring team in a free tutoring and mentoring program. Model Mentor Award, 2026.

Student Volunteer, Liberty in North Korea (LiNK), North Jersey Rescue Team — 2023 to present
Helps at awareness events and fundraisers organized with national LiNK.

SCHOOL LEADERSHIP

Founder and Editor-in-Chief, *ADM*, the Visual Academy's art and design magazine

Leads 15 to 20 students through content, interviews, editing, visual direction, layout, printing, and distribution.

2025 to 2027

Head of Design, *LitMag*, BCA's award-winning literary and art magazine

Teaches younger students Adobe InDesign, assigns design tasks, designs each cover, and assembles the final publication.

2024 to 2026

Leadership Team, Academy of Visual Arts (appointed by faculty)

Media Team (selected), Chocolate Competition, Academy for Culinary Arts and Hospitality Administration

Badges, tickets, showbook, name tags, and show-day photography.

2025, 2026

Leadership Team, Haunted Mansion Project

Ran one room of the school-wide theatrical event.

2024, 2026

TEACHING

Art Instructor (volunteer), Krafty Kids Workshop, Palisades Park Library — 2023 to present

Teaches biweekly children's art and craft classes; 110 volunteer hours. Turns students' artwork into murals for the library walls.

Art Director (paid), ROARS Summer Camp, Chodae Church — Summer 2024

Wrote and taught the art curriculum for about 60 students, Pre-K 4 through fifth grade.

Summer Art Instructor, Townsville Montessori School — Summer 2024

Art Class Assistant, Give Chance Sunday art classes, a Palisades Park nonprofit serving low-income families — 2025

Private Writing and Art Tutor (paid) — 2025 to 2026